

PRAYING FOR FRUIT
Coconut trees along a road in Old Goa

INDIA PICTURE

EST NUT TO CRACK

enough coconuts to feed its tourist boom—and itself

per cent—has to be imported from Karnataka, Kerala, Tamil Nadu et al. During the Ganesh festival in late August, when demand rose, the Goa State Horticulture Corporation imported 75,000 coconuts from Karnataka and sold them to consumers at a subsidised Rs 40-45 per piece. Otherwise, retail prices range from Rs 80 to Rs 100 per coconut, depending on its size (and the market's location). Wholesale rates vary from Rs 29 to Rs 50 per coconut.

COCONUT PER CAPITA

If coconut prices are pinching the pockets of local consumers, put it down to a double whammy: production falling amidst a rising demand graph due to tourism. "Goa is a tourist destination, and tourists relish fish curry and rice. So, consumption is growing, and we need more coconuts, but we have limited geographical area," says Sandeep Foldessai, director at the state government's directorate of agriculture.

Goa's total land area is 370,200 hectares. In 2025, about 38.77 per cent of this was under farming—down from 39.58 per cent in 2019-20. Coconut plantations, even with a slightly rising footprint, cover only a modest 26,807 hectares. In 2022-23, Goa's production was 163.1 million coconuts. This fell to 160.9 million in 2023-24, and further to 150.8 million in 2024-25, with a per hectare decline in productivity from 6,113 coconuts to 6,006 and 5,625.

Narendra Sawaikar, former BJP MP from South Goa and chairman of Goa's largest cooperative society, attributes the decline chiefly to mite infestation—apparently the result of climatic changes—and crop destruction by monkeys. "The area under coconut cultivation has actually risen, but the production has declined," he observes.

SENILE PLANTATIONS

Many coconut plantations have also aged, having neared their natural productive cycle of 80-90 years, says Foldessai. The earlier advent of monsoon rains has also affected harvesting cycles. Goa needs to urgently rejuvenate its senile plantations, he adds.

The issue has elicited cross-party concern. Replying to the Goa Forward Party's Vijai Sardesai in the assembly, agriculture minister Ravi Naik said Goa has to import both mature and tender coconuts due to the high influx of tourists and the concomitant rise in demand from hotels and restaurants. Independent MLA Aleixo Reginaldo Lourenco, who raised the issue in the House, calls for subsidies. "Coconuts are a lifeline. Their oil, water and shreddings are good for health. Coconut oil is healthier than processed oils," says Lourenco.

In January-June 2025, Goa saw a record 5.45 million tourists arrivals, an 8.4 per cent surge, so the year's figures may surpass the 10.4 million of 2024. Add 1.6 million locals. Even on a lazy Goan holiday, you can do the rough math on how many millions will be looking for some coconut nirvana. ■

Takeaways

- **With local output falling to 150.8 million, Goa has to import 60% of its coconuts from Karnataka, TN et al**
- **Goa has limited area. Its local plantations also suffer from pest infestation, simian attacks and senility**